Withering Souls

It was a Tuesday afternoon, around 3 PM. I left my work shift early when I received a text message regarding my mother's worsening condition. Even after intense treatment and medication, her cancer had spread to her vital organs. Thinking about her steadily declining situation hurt in a way I couldn't name. I often find myself wondering if I'm a bad daughter for not being able to alleviate her pain. This week, I've worked for 60 hours, but I still don't feel like my efforts are enough to satisfy my mother's or my brother's needs.

My boss called me in the car, asking why I left work so early. I told him my circumstances, as I have been doing from time to time for the past months. Despite my pleas, despite my appeal to his human emotion, this unsympathetic man fails to see the severity of my situation; his stern stance doesn't seem to buckle. I cannot just leave my mother alone in the hospital as her condition worsens. What kind of daughter walks away from their dying mother? At the same time, I also cannot risk losing my job. My brother's present and future are in my hands now, and, at his young age of 15, he does not yet understand the cruelness of this world.

While the fog of these thoughts perpetuates in my mind, and the weight of my brother drops on my shoulders, I miss the detail that the yellow light in front of me had quickly turned red. By the time I snapped back to reality, it was already too late. The truck's horn blared at me as I ran the red light thoughtlessly. I remembered much of the moment that it happened: The truck crushing the right side of my red Volkswagen punch buggy, the ear-bursting sound of metal crumbling, the

violent impact of the airbag on my face and chest as well as my inaudible screams, the screech of the tires and brakes, and the dizzying, blurring sight of my car rolling through the intersection. Next came the scratching sound as the side of my car skid across the pavement, with the top of the car smashing the metal traffic pole, finally halting the vehicle to a sudden stop. I remember the nebulous images of the pedestrians, their faces registering total shock, appearing to me from sideways, and then, everything went black.

I awoke on a hospital bed. The steady beep of my heartbeat was the first sound I heard. Next, I saw my brother, who was standing beside my bed, complaining under his breath. He didn't seem happy at all, but who can blame him?

His scolding voice hurts my heart as he says that I only had one job, which I couldn't even do correctly. I lie there staring up at the white ceiling, my body resisting as I try to speak.

I close my eyes and drift off to sleep again. I feel as if I'm drowning, as if my ankles are chained to the bottom of the ocean. I feel disappointed in myself for leaving my brother alone and for letting my mother's condition slip out of my control. I wish I could just die. Death must be better than this, right? Death must mean freedom from life and its pains, from inconvenience, and from hatred.

I'm awakened by the flashing lights, the whirring of wheels on the sterile hospital floors. Am I being transported somewhere? The light-blue ceiling lights send shivers down my spine. The doors open, and the slight bump from the doorway shakes the bed. I hear the door close, shutting out the outer world. There was no smell, minimal light, and I couldn't feel the texture of my

surroundings in my heavily sedated state. The doctor administers another round of that numbing substance, as I feel a cold fluid spread throughout my body. Soon after**,** I feel the pain of the scalpel entering my body. My eyes widen, and I shout. The doctors seem frightened and confused. I yell at them to stop, but they don't react. My pain is too great to focus. There's a shock on one of the doctor's faces as he observes my vitals. I can feel the sense of worry, and I realize I'm going to die. I feel confused and lost. Does freedom outweigh leaving loved ones behind and letting others down? Was this what death meant? In that case, I don't want it anymore. I want to go back to my family. My brother will have no one if I die. My job is not finished, and leaving this world behind is something I cannot comprehend. I cry, and I cry, as I start to feel disconnected from my own body. My pain does not ease up, but rather intensifies as I feel myself departing. I feel guilty, a traitor to my mother and brother. I shouldn't have underestimated death, praying for my own demise. I should have paid more attention to the road.

The thoughts stop. I can't think anymore. I can't move, can't shout; I can only feel pain and guilt. Now I realize I have been trapped in this feeling for eternity, with nowhere to go, no purpose to serve, only to suffer for the rest of time.

I miss my sister's comfort. It has been a few weeks since she died. Ignoring her requests to spend time with me is something I will carry with me forever. I always hated it when she would start complaining about how much time I spent by myself. It really shows, as in these few weeks, I have been fired four times after not being able to coexist with my co-workers. With savings

dwindling, I'm starting to worry about my mum. If I can't support her hospital bills, they will cut her off from life support. I will be alone in this cruel world. Why did I treat my sister like a slave? She worked overtime and pulled all-nighters just to support my education and my mother's healthcare. Why could I not just show some sympathy? I am the reason for my sister's death.

The locker beside me slammed shut with a loud bang. I just finished a miserable history lecture, and I'm literally about to collapse onto the ground from exhaustion. I wish I could just go home and sleep in my bed, but it seems my day is about to get a lot worse. As my eyes drift to my right and upwards, I recognize the six-foot-four mass staring at me. It's Michael. I've been the victim of his bullying for the last few years, just like a quarter of the entire school, but apparently, I'm his victim of choice today, I guess. I've been his homework, his money man, and punching bag. He's the reason I've considered every uncivil act against my own existence.

Not long ago, I wondered, what if I had just killed him? All my problems would disappear. My head was slammed against one of the urinals, which broke my nose, and now, he was about to jump me, along with his five-man gang. I tried running, but my short body and legs could not outrun a quarter of the football team. I tripped, sliding across the hard, dirty hallway floor. I tried getting back up, but I wasn't fast enough. They punched me hard. I flew backwards, hitting my head on the ground. They kicked my chest as I gasped for air, but my lungs didn't work. Then they took my belongings and stomped on my head as I slowly lost my vision.

As I opened my eyes, a red tint surrounded my vision. A stinging sensation filled my eyes, making it impossible to see. My head felt like a ticking time bomb, throbbing with every second that passed. As I brought my hand to my head, I felt a wet and warm liquid on my face. Crap, they busted my head open. My chest felt like it had collapsed. I tried to push myself off the ground but felt a piercing pain in my left leg. I could barely even walk.

For a moment, I wanted them gone. All of them. All my troubles would disappear.

In the distance, I saw a van and the bullies. I knew what I was going to do: End their worthless lives along with my own. I broke the window of the vehicle, jumped in, and started driving. I floored the gas, and the car began to accelerate, the momentum pushing my back against the driver's seat. It wasn't long before the sidewalks blurred in my peripheral vision. I mowed them down, feeling the satisfying bumps of each one of their bodies getting crushed beneath the car—their bodies flattened, their lives ended. There was an intersection up ahead. I sped up, hoping to crash into another car, or to crash into a post or building, to die on impact. As I approached the intersection, I closed my eyes. I pushed my head against the horn, blazing it as if I was signaling my death, a glorious one in my mind. A worthwhile sacrifice for my mother and sister.

I felt the impact. It was as if a small rock had hit my body. A slight bump was definitely not what I was expecting. My huge mass clearly shouldn't justify such a low intensity crash feeling, right?

I stopped the truck out of confusion. I had just stolen a commercial truck and killed five people, with a potential extra person. The plan was to die, and suffering the consequences of such an act in jail was definitely not the plan. Where should I hide? Where do I run to? My world became silent as I brought myself to think. No one seemed to notice me, only the car I had completely demolished a moment ago. The car was flipped over, on its back, and covered in scratches with a crater on one side. And so with nowhere else to go, I ran back home.

The next day, my aunt arrived at my house. My sister didn't come home, yet we began to drive to the hospital. I asked her where my sister was. "It isn't your mother we are visiting today," she says. That's when it struck me. A cold sweat emerged from my back, sticking my shirt to my back as I wondered if my aunt knew what had happened yesterday.

I entered her hospital room, my legs shaking uncontrollably. I don't know what I was thinking about. I was confused, confused about everything. "It was a car crash," the doctor informed me. I asked her if the perpetrator had been found. "No."

What was I supposed to think? What was I supposed to say? What was I meant to do in this situation? I don't know. I felt hatred for those bullies. The anger stirred up in my belly, and I

shouted at my sister. As the words left my mouth, I felt a strong sense of regret. How could I say those words to my sister? My victim? I ran out of the room, back home, tears in my eyes, as they flowed down my cheeks and dripped onto the concrete sidewalk. It hurt me to breathe, to think. I ran by the collision scene. What if my sister never gets better? What would I do? The world slowed down around me, and I felt as if everybody was watching, determining my fate. I stood still, staring directly at the crash site. Right where my sister was a day ago. I felt her gaze on me, her anger, frustration, and sadness. A strange sensation of guilt and mercy flew through my face. I couldn't bear this feeling anymore. I ran back home, sat in the corner of my room, and pointed a gun at my mouth. I sat there for as long as I can remember. I had a finger on the trigger, tears dripping from my chin, forming a puddle on the floor. I sat there, groaning in confusion and pain, until my aunt came to check on me. Until she opened the door, took the gun, and left me sitting there, not understanding why my life had to be bad, why I had to be bullied. My aunt cried outside the door as she wept the words I would never have wanted to hear, the words that marked my sister's death. And I was left there in disbelief, with the realization that I had just killed my sister. I could not move, and I could not understand the reality of my situation. The desperation in my mind grew. And I could not bring myself to stand up, to walk out of the house, to do anything at all, as I felt that my world, and my life, had collapsed.

It has been two months or so, and I have learned to, in a way, deal with it. I work whenever I can, sometimes even overtime, to keep up with my mother's hospital bills and my school fees. I have not been catching up on schoolwork and have failed a couple of tests already. I seriously don't know how my sister did it. The nagging and bombardment from her bosses even ticked me off at times. Sometimes, I just wanted to act out of order, maybe talk back to them, but I realized over time that doing so would just get me fired and replaced.

I just couldn't imagine my sister having to go through the constant nitpicking and nagging just to provide enough income for my mother and me. Sometimes she would be a little bit mean to me, ignoring my requests for food and help with homework. Sometimes she would act really annoyed at me, rolling her eyes when I complained. But now I realize that she was a very caring and loving person. I wish I could have noticed this sooner and embraced it. I wish that I could go back in time and comfort her during these difficult moments. I wish I could take back my harsh words towards her. But I can't. She never hated me. It was always only I who made myself feel like utter garbage. I cannot do anything about the situation now, and that absolutely crushes my heart.

I constantly feel like an imposter at school. The guilt of the deaths of those five people is unbearable. Having to go to school every day, pass by the murder scene, and have people at school talk about their deaths, not knowing that they were speaking to the murderer, has taken a toll on my energy. Through these conversations, I have learned a great deal. These students weren't born to hate or born bad. Their family conditions were terrible. A lot worse than mine. Some of them had parents who had killed each other. Some had abusive ones. Some didn't even

have one. But I did. How could I not have realized the loving people I had so close to me, who were always there for me? People who would cry and sob and mourn when I die. I didn't die. But I took the lives of five students with ruined families out of pure hatred. I took the life of my sister, someone who truly loved me.

I had everything: A family to lean on, a sister who provided for me with her blood, sweat, and tears, and then there were those five bullies, students who could have used my compassion. My eyes close as I pass out while these ideas fly around in my head.

I look around me, and I see a daisy field, never-ending, wrapped around the edge, falling off the horizon. In the distance, there is a massive willow tree. Its vast size and protection remind me of the big umbrella my mother used to take me under when I was a little boy. As the cool breeze blew past, the petals rained down so gently, so calmly, soothing my soul.

I see my sister under the tree, reading a book with blank pages. I ask her what she is reading. She doesn't answer me. Obviously invested in this story, I ask her again. This time, her reply is simple.

"You wouldn't understand."

She stares at something behind me, and I turn to observe what it is. Nothing is there, except for an endless field of daisies.

"Sister, what are you talking about?" I say as I turn back. But she is gone. Replacing her are my five bullies. I am prepared to run away before I feel their unexpected welcoming aura. Again, all are reading their books - books with blank pages.

I ask again, except this time, they disappear, and my mother replaces them all.

"Mother?" I ask in confusion.

She doesn't speak. Instead, she just nods slightly.

I turn around. Reappearing in the field of daisies is my sister and the five bullies. Their memories play themselves out to me like movies. I can finally see their lives. They are holding black books, thick black books, overflowing with words. Just observing them put a sharp pain in my head, instantly filling my body with an overwhelming feeling of stress and anxiety. A feeling that I didn't quite understand. I never saw into their lives - perhaps that was the issue all along. If only I had given them a chance, I could have understood their hardships and how they weren't inherently annoying or mean at all. No, they were innocent people plagued by societal norms to rage, to crumble, and I killed them.

"Do you understand now?" My mother asks me, while fading into the morning sky.

Before I could respond at all, I shot up off the couch, drenched in a cold sweat. I rushed to the hospital, before shedding my tears beside my mother's hospital bed as she flatlined.